is using Sangh affiliates to communicate the welfare narrative to the people here, while highlighting the TMC's alleged neglect of tribals. Odisha chief minister Mohan Charan Majhi, a tribal face, has been roped in to campaign in these constituencies.

In South Bengal, where the Trinamool remains strong, the BJP's aims are considerably more modest: increase the turnout by 3-5 per cent, add 3,000-6,000 votes per seat and use targeted outreach among traders, women and lower-middle-class voters to split voting blocs. Meanwhile, in the border districts, where the Matuas remain central, the BJP has softened the citizenship narrative, particularly after the SIR exercise, so as not to alienate them and also retain the Bongaon stronghold. Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma, relieved of election duties in his home state, has been enlisted to campaign in these parts.

The Minority Split

The BJP is also hoping that the minority vote itself may no longer be monolithic and may split the TMC vote. The Congress is attempting a revival, especially in districts such as Malda and Murshidabad. Mausam Benazir Noor, a former MP who returned to the Congress from the TMC and is contesting from the Malatipur seat in Malda, believes that the Muslim vote may not consolidate behind Mamata as it did in 2021. "Some of the honourable chief minister's actions and statements have angered people here," she asserts. Citing the arrest of advocate Mofakkerul Islam after protests in Mothabari and Mamata's remark about "a certain community" finishing off others if TMC doesn't come to power, Noor interpreted them as being anti-minority. Another battleground has emerged in Berhampore, where former Congress MP and veteran leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury takes on the TMC's Naru Gopal Mukherjee and the sitting MLA Subrata Maitra of the BJP. Both Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and his sister Priyanka Vadra have also begun addressing rallies. The Left Front, too, though diminished, remains a variable. With a 6.3 per cent vote share in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, it could influence outcomes if it retains its base.

Trouble for the TMC is coming from other quarters too. On April 13, the Enforcement Directorate arrested I-PAC co-founder Vinesh Chandel in Delhi in an alleged 'coal scam'. Terming it as an attempt by the BJP to bully the TMC, Abhishek said, "The arrest of Vinesh Chandel, barely 10 days before the Bengal election, is not just alarming, it shakes the very idea of a level-playing field. That's not democracy, it's intimidation."



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OTHER PLAYERS Congress's Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury campaigns in Murshidabad, Apr. 9; Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya of the CPI(M) in Kolkata, Apr. 6

Relying on a booth-level strategy, the BJP is hoping to add 10-15 voters per booth, which could add up to 2,500-3,000 additional votes per constituency, enough to flip close contests